fortune can one have than to learn the rudiments of climbing in the Himalayas from Tenzing Norgay. This legendary mountaineer, who had the unique honour of being the first man to climb the mighty Everest, along with Sir Edmund Hillary, was the director of field training when I did my basic and advanced mountaineering courses at the Himalayan Mountaineering Institute, Darjeeling in the 1960s. This experience and knowledge came in very handy for me later in life, while dealing with the challenges on our high-altitude border with China – along the LAC in Ladakh, Joshimath Sector and the northeast, and the AGPL or LoC in Siachen, Kargil and Kashmir regions. In our case, for reasons that are obvious, it is of vital importance to understand, particularly at the senior levels, the challenges posed by mountainous and high-altitude terrain in warfare. We learnt this lesson to our bitter cost during the Chinese aggression in 1962.



The army women's successful Everest expedition flagged in by Defence Minister Pranab Mukherjee and me in June 2005.